with the idea of making a speech of his own to counter Kennedy's. Mikoyan tried to prevent him from making any statements running counter to the Soviet position and wrote to Moscow asking that Dobrynin be instructed to warn Robert Kennedy and, through him, the president not to attack Castro, as that would complicate the conclusion of the agreement between Kennedy and Khrushchev.[20]

Castro was afraid of what Kennedy might say in his speech and yet had high hopes for it. Fearing a humiliating attack on Cuba, he hoped for such an attack on the Soviet Union. "I consider that you have already made the decision to withdraw the IL-28s," said Castro to Mikoyan, "but if Kennedy makes a threatening and arrogant announcement, he will thereby place the Soviet Union in an unpleasant and difficult position." He assured Mikoyan that the Cubans were prepared to withstand the blockade: "We should not fear the blockade. It will not break the revolution." Mikoyan remained impervious to Castro's revolutionary rhetoric. "I did not find it necessary, feeling Fidel's weariness, to explain the erroneousness of his judgments in that conversation," reported Mikoyan to Moscow. He decided to drop the issue, leaving Castro at least a glimmer of hope that if not Khrushchev through his actions, then Kennedy through his words might help him keep his bombers.[21]

Mikoyan's report was typed for distribution to the Presidium members on November 29 at 11:40 a.m. Moscow time. By that time Khrushchev had already made up his mind.